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Enter more bid rounds without hiring

Bids are now won on evidence, not hours. How a senior team scales with agents doing the first drafts.

Solar and battery storage | Bids and tenders

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ABSTRACT

UK onshore solar and battery developers now win revenue through a chain of competitions rather than a single auction: a Contracts for Difference (CfD) round, a route-to-market or corporate PPA, a battery toll or floor, a Capacity Market auction and a Gate 2 grid offer. Using public results from AR7a, the AR8 notices, the Capacity Market and NESO's connections reform, this paper argues that the binding constraint for a growth-stage IPP is no longer the number of projects, but the senior time needed to turn one body of project evidence into many consistent, well-priced bids. We describe where that time and value are lost, why conventional bid desks break at portfolio scale, and an eight-step workflow in which AI agents do the first drafts and cross-checks while named people own every price, risk and sign-off. Our illustrative model shows the senior team getting twice the time on what wins the deal, with fewer hours in total. A worked solar and battery example, also clearly labelled as illustrative, shows what a single pricing or timing decision is worth.

KEY FINDINGS

1

Price discipline is tightening.

AR7a cleared 4.9 GW of solar across 157 projects at £65.23/MWh, 13% below the administrative strike price. For AR8, government will see anonymised bids and set budgets only after applications are assessed. [1] [3]

2

Revenue is assembled from several bids, not one.

CfD, PPA, battery tolls and floors, the Capacity Market and Gate 2 each have their own rules and counterparties. All of them draw on the same project evidence. [12] [13] [15] [17]

3

The grid queue has become a deadline.

Reform cut a queue of over 700 GW to a 283 GW pipeline. A Gate 2 transmission offer must be signed within 90 days, and some distribution offers within 30. The grid date now drives every other bid. [8] [11] [20]

4

Merchant price signals are weaker than they were.

The T-4 Capacity Market price fell from £60 to £27.10/kW/year. In GB PPAs, buyers' best bids sit £5–10/MWh below sellers' offers, and no transactable price was observed. [12] [14]

5

Twice the time on what wins the deal, and still fewer hours.

In our illustrative model, agents take on coordination, drafting and reconciliation. Senior time on judgement, relationships, strategy and negotiation doubles, while total senior hours per bid fall by about 30%. A 12-project IPP's bid load drops from 121% of a four-person desk's capacity to about 84%.

KEY TERMS

Contracts for Difference (CfD)
UK scheme paying a generator the gap between a fixed strike price and a market reference price. From AR7, contracts for wind and solar run 20 years and are CPI-indexed. [6]

Allocation round (AR7, AR7a, AR8)
A competitive CfD auction. Projects bid sealed strike prices by pot, and successful projects receive the clearing price for their pot. [1] [3]

Administrative strike price (ASP)
The maximum strike price a technology can receive in a round. For solar it is £75/MWh in 2024 prices for both AR7 and AR8. [3]

Gate 2
The stage of GB connections reform at which a project that is ready and strategically aligned receives a firm connection offer with a confirmed date. 8

Tolling agreement
A battery contract in which an offtaker pays a fixed fee for dispatch rights. The owner keeps responsibility for construction and availability. 15

Floor (BESS)
A contract guaranteeing a minimum battery revenue while the owner keeps upside above it. 17

1 · THE LANDSCAPE

What has changed in UK solar and battery bidding since AR7?

SHORT ANSWER

Three things. CfD rounds now reward tighter pricing: solar cleared 13% below its cap in AR7a, and AR8 adds government sight of bids. Offtake is split across PPAs, tolls, floors and the Capacity Market. And grid reform has turned connection dates into hard deadlines. 1 3 8

CfD: more capacity, sharper prices

AR7a, the onshore and solar half of the seventh round, awarded 4,905 MW of solar to 157 projects and 1,306 MW of onshore wind to 28 projects. Every successful solar project received £65.23/MWh in 2024 prices, against an administrative strike price of £75. Onshore wind cleared at £72.24 against £92. 1 Across AR7 as a whole, government reported 14.7 GW from 201 projects. 2

The results table also shows who is winning. We parsed all 157 solar awards. The median project is 29.9 MW, 84 of the 157 projects are 30 MW or smaller, and 24 sit between 49 and 50 MW. 134 are in England. 1 For a growth-stage IPP this is the relevant competition: many mid-sized projects bidding at one clearing price, where a few pounds per MWh separate a contract from a lost year.

AR8 changes the rules again. The Price and Pot Notice puts solar alone in Pot 1 and onshore wind in Pot 2. It keeps the AR7 strike price caps, gives government sight of anonymised sealed bids in Pots 1–4, and states that budgets will be confirmed only after applications have been assessed, with value for money as a key test. 3 The application window ran from 20 July to 7 August 2026, with Pot 1 delivery years from 2028/29 to 2030/31. 4 NESO's Notice of Auction and the Contract Budget Notice are scheduled for 19 November 2026. 5

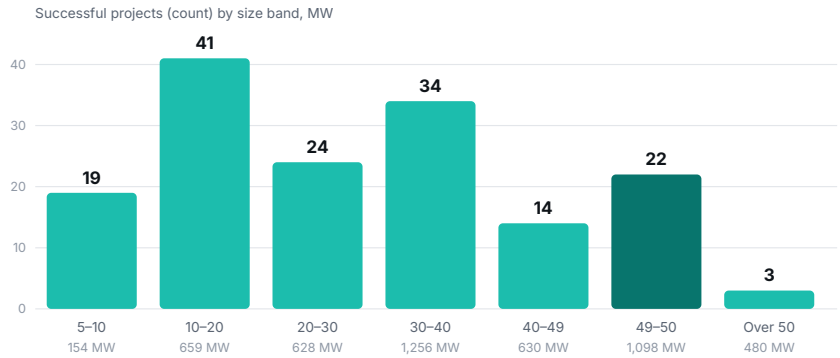


FIGURE 1

AR7a solar awards cluster in mid-sized projects

Successful AR7a solar projects by capacity band. 157 projects, 4,905 MW in total. The darker bar marks projects of 49–50 MW. Source: Ignis analysis of the DESNZ AR7a results table. 1

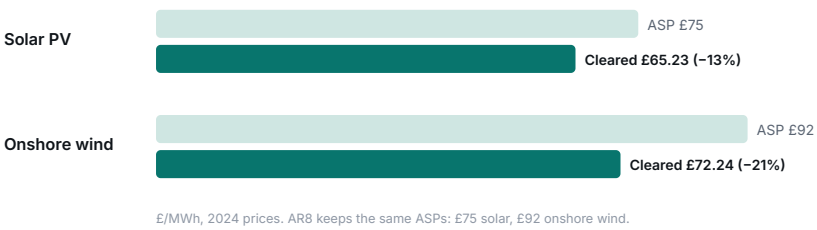


FIGURE 2

AR7a cleared well below the price caps that AR8 keeps

Administrative strike price against AR7a clearing price, £/MWh in 2024 prices. Source: DESNZ AR7a results and AR8 Price and Pot Notice. 1 3

Offtake: a thinner, more demanding PPA market

Veyt recorded 27 UK PPAs totalling 1.8 GW in 2025, down 0.5 GW year on year. Across Europe, corporate PPA activity fell 19% while route-to-market PPAs tripled to 15 contracts. [13] Pexapark counted 24 GB PPAs (626 MW) announced by October 2025, a 39% fall. It reports sell-side offers for 10-year pay-as-produced solar of £74–84/MWh, while buyers' best bids sit £5–10 lower, so no transactable price was observed. [14] The two databases count differently, which is why their totals differ. Both point the same way.

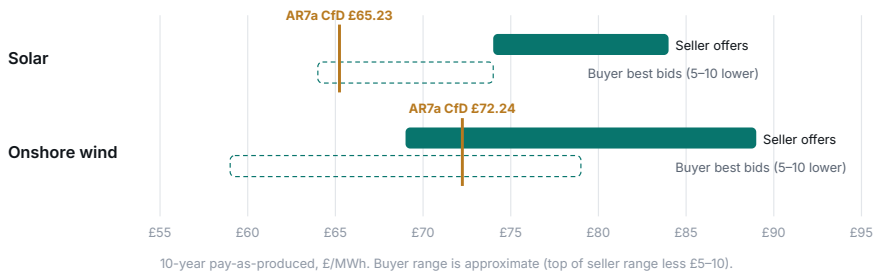


FIGURE 3

GB new-build PPAs: sellers benchmark to CfD, buyers will not follow

Pexapark's quoted sell-side range for 10-year pay-as-produced PPAs, an approximate buyer range, and the AR7a CfD clearing price. Source: Pexapark (Nov 2025); DESNZ AR7a. [14] [1] The CfD price is in 2024 prices and CPI-indexed; PPA quotes are not directly comparable.

Batteries: tolls, floors and a cheaper Capacity Market

Battery revenue is being contracted in new ways. Drax signed a 10-year, CPI-indexed toll for Fidra's 250 MW / 500 MWh West Burton project, subject to final investment decision (FID) by Q3 2026, [15] and a 15-year, non-indexed toll for Zenobē's 200 MW / 800 MWh Coalburn site. [16] In both, the owner keeps construction and availability risk. Gresham House signed a revenue floor with Statkraft and a revenue swap with Nephila Climate and Markel, together securing £35m a year across 789 MW. Modo estimates the floor at about £44k/MW/year. [17]

TABLE 1

Three public battery contract structures

DEAL	ASSET	STRUCTURE	TERM AND INDEXATION	WHO KEEPS BUILD AND AVAILABILITY RISK
Drax and Fidra [15]	250 MW / 500 MWh	Toll	10 years, CPI-indexed	Owner
Drax and Zenobē [16]	200 MW / 800 MWh	Toll	15 years, not indexed	Owner
Gresham House with Statkraft, Nephila and Markel [17]	789 MW portfolio	Revenue floor and revenue swap	£35m a year secured; Modo estimate about £44k/MW/year	Owner, with upside retained

Every structure needs a different revenue case, contract mark-up and lender pack built from the same asset data. Source: Company announcements and Modo Energy. [15] [16] [17]

The Capacity Market sends a weaker signal than before. The 2029/30 T-4 auction cleared at £27.10/kW/year, down from £60 the previous year. It awarded 40.1 GW of de-rated capacity, of which batteries took 1.2 GW (3.0%). [12]

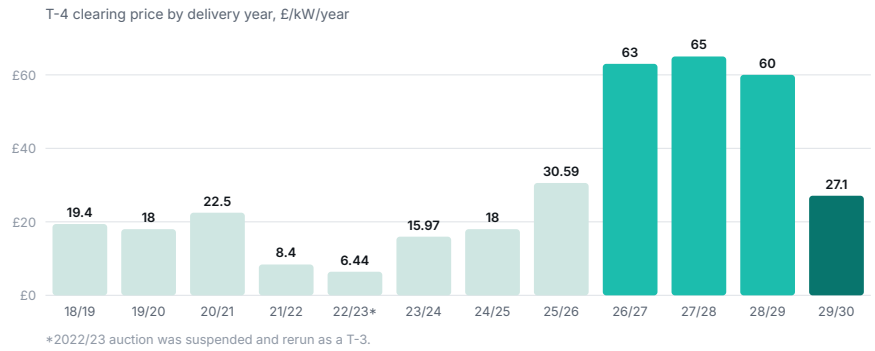


FIGURE 4

Capacity Market T-4 prices more than halved in one year

T-4 clearing prices by delivery year, £/kW/year. Source: Ofgem annual report on the Capacity Market 2025/26, Table 1. [12]

Grid: from queue to deadline

NESO's reform replaced a first-come queue of over 700 GW, about four times projected 2030 need, with a 283 GW pipeline of generation and storage. [8] Of that, 132 GW is aligned with Clean Power 2030 (Phase 1) and a further 151 GW is needed by 2035 (Phase 2). [9] By 10 June 2026, 713 of the 1,223 projects in the pre-2030 pipeline (58%) had received offers, totalling 37 GW. [10] NESO gives 90 days to sign a Gate 2 transmission offer, [11] while National Grid Electricity Distribution gives 30 days for its Gate 2 variation offers. [20] Phase 2 transmission offers run from early September 2026 to mid-January 2027, [18] and Ofgem has set 31 January 2027 as the deadline for issuing them. [19] Clean Power 2030 still needs solar to roughly triple and batteries to grow about fivefold. [7] The volume is there; access to it is now rationed by readiness and by dates.

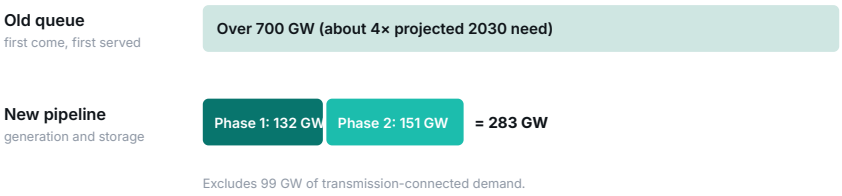


FIGURE 5

Connections reform cut the queue to the projects that can be built

GB connection queue before reform against the new pipeline. Source: NESO news release and press release (8 Dec 2025). [8] [9]

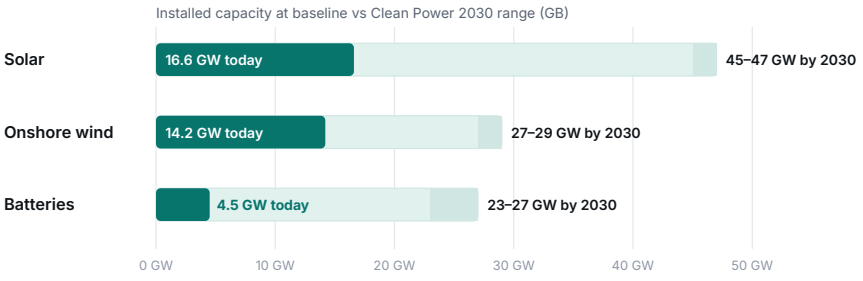


FIGURE 6

Clean Power 2030 still needs a step change in solar and batteries

Baseline capacity against the Clean Power 2030 range. Source: DESNZ Clean Power 2030 Action Plan, Table 1 (current installed capacity at publication). [7]

2 · ANALYSIS

Where are bid time and value lost?

SHORT ANSWER

Mostly before and between documents, not in them. Time goes on late bid or no-bid calls, evidence rebuilt for each bid, pricing models that drift from the latest inputs, inconsistencies between submissions, and lessons that are never written down. Each of these costs margin as well as hours.

There is no public dataset on bid hours in UK renewables, so this section is analysis rather than measurement. It draws on how the competitions above are structured and on Ignis practitioner experience. We see five recurring loss points. Each one

is a place where senior time goes into production rather than judgement, or where an error reaches the counterparty.

1

Late bid or no-bid call

Teams start drafting before the price floor, grid date and partner position are agreed. Weeks are spent on bids that should have been declined.

COST Wasted bid cost, and senior focus taken off the bids that matter

2

Evidence rebuilt each time

Land, planning, grid, yield and cost evidence is gathered again for each CfD, PPA or toll pack.

COST Hours lost, and stale inputs in front of buyers and lenders

3

Pricing drift

The bid model, board paper and counterparty term sheet use different capex or yield assumptions.

COST Bids priced below viability, or a contract won at a loss

4

Inconsistent submissions

Delivery years, capacity and grid dates differ across CfD, PPA and Gate 2 documents.

COST Clarification questions, credibility loss and delivery-year risk

5

Lessons not captured

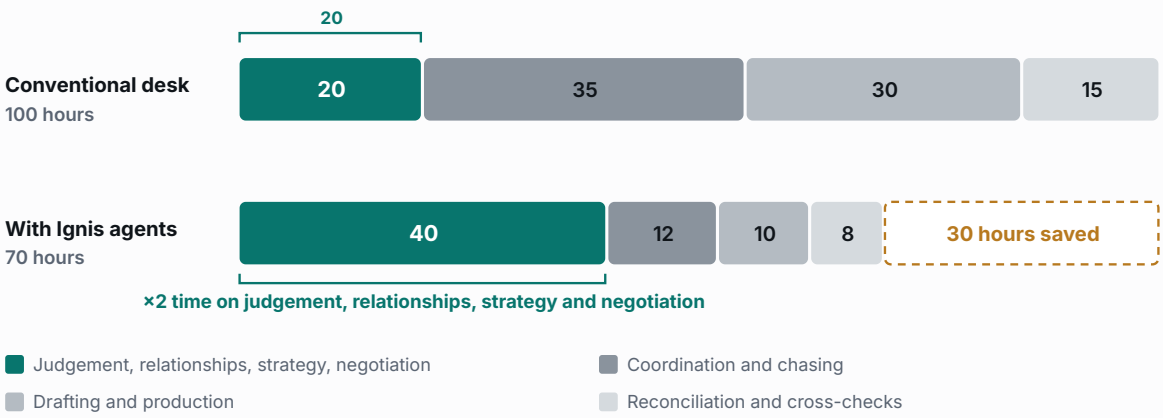
Debriefs and clearing data are not fed back into the next bid.

COST The same mistakes repeated across rounds

The pattern is consistent. The scarce people, usually the CEO, the commercial director and one or two senior managers, spend most of their bid time on chasing inputs, drafting and reconciling documents. Judgement, buyer and partner relationships, strategy and negotiation are the work that wins the deal, and they get whatever time is left over. Figure 7 sets out the alternative as an illustrative model: twice the time on what wins the deal, and still fewer hours.

FIGURE 7 ILLUSTRATIVE

Twice the time on what wins the deal, and still fewer hours



Senior hours on one mid-sized CfD or PPA bid. Assumptions: a conventional desk spends 100 senior hours, 20 on judgement, relationships, strategy and negotiation and 80 on coordination, production and reconciliation. With agents doing first drafts, chasing and cross-checks, the other work falls to 30 hours and the team reinvests 20 hours, doubling judgement time to 40. Total: 70 hours, so 30 are saved. Source: Ignis illustrative model. These are not measured data; see Method and assumptions.

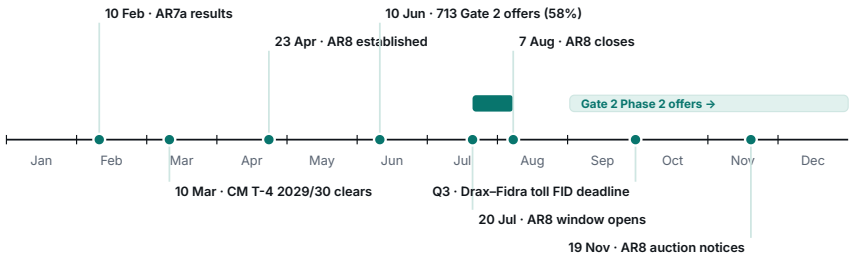
3 · ANALYSIS

Why do conventional bid desks break at portfolio scale?

SHORT ANSWER

Because the number of bid events grows with projects multiplied by revenue streams, while the number of senior people stays flat. A 12-project IPP can face dozens of CfD, PPA, toll, Capacity Market and Gate 2 events a year, many in the same months. The desk runs out of senior hours before it runs out of projects.

A single-asset developer can run one bid at a time. A fund-backed IPP with 5 to 20 projects cannot. Each project may need a CfD application, a route-to-market or corporate PPA, a battery toll or floor, Capacity Market prequalification and a Gate 2 acceptance, and these deadlines overlap. In 2026 alone, the AR8 window, the T-4 results, a published battery-toll FID deadline and the Gate 2 offer wave all fell within a few months of each other (Figure 8).



Shaded band: Gate 2 Phase 2 transmission offers, early Sep 2026 to mid-Jan 2027 (Ofgem deadline 31 Jan 2027).

FIGURE 8

2026: public bid and grid deadlines overlap

Selected public UK bid and grid dates in 2026. Source: DESNZ, CfD microsite, Ofgem, NESO, Drax. [1] [4] [5] [10] [12] [15] [18] [19]

TABLE 2 ILLUSTRATIVE

Illustrative: annual senior bid load for a 12-project IPP

BID EVENT	EVENTS PER YEAR	SENIOR HOURS EACH	TOTAL HOURS
CfD applications	6	300	1,800
PPA (route-to-market or corporate)	6	150	900
Battery toll, floor or optimiser	4	150	600
Capacity Market prequalification and bid	4	60	240
Gate 2 offer review and acceptance	8	40	320
Total demand	**28**		**3,860**
Capacity: 4 senior people × 1,600 hours × 50% on bids			3,200
Load against capacity, conventional desk			**121%**
Load with agent support (70 hours per 100, Figure 7)			**about 84%**

With agent support, demand falls from 3,860 to about 2,700 hours, while time on judgement, relationships and negotiation rises from about 770 to 1,540 hours. Above capacity, the nearest deadline sets the bid strategy; below it, the senior team does. Source: Ignis illustrative model. Event counts and hours are assumptions, not measured data.

Three things break first. **Key people:** one commercial director holds the price logic for every bid. **Consistency:** the same project is described differently to DESNZ, a PPA buyer, a toll counterparty and NESO. **Learning:** when the desk is over capacity, the debrief is the first thing to go. Hiring helps only slowly. A senior bid manager who knows CfD rules, PPA terms and lender requirements takes months to find and longer to bring up to speed.

4 · THE WORKFLOW

How does an agentic bid workflow work?

SHORT ANSWER

It runs every bid through the same eight steps on one shared body of evidence. AI agents read the rules, assemble evidence, produce first drafts and cross-check numbers. A named person makes each decision and signs it off at a gate. The output is a bid, plus a record that the next bid can reuse.

The design principle is borrowed from good investment committees: separate the preparation from the decision, and keep both on the record. Agents are good at reading long rule books, comparing documents and drafting to a template. People are needed for price, risk appetite, partner terms and anything that commits the company. The eight steps in Figure 9 apply whether the bid is a CfD application, a PPA tender, a toll, a Capacity Market entry or a Gate 2 acceptance.

FIGURE 9

The eight-step agent-supported bid workflow

		AGENTS	YOU DECIDE
01	**Intake and rules**	Reads the rules, extracts requirements, dates and scoring into a checklist	Confirms scope and deadline owner
02	**Bid or no-bid**	Builds a one-page view of fit, price floor, grid date and competition	Decides go or no-go, with a written reason
03	**Evidence library**	Pulls land, planning, grid, yield and cost evidence, and flags gaps and stale items	Approves what counts as current evidence
04	**Pricing and revenue**	Runs the model with linked inputs and produces scenarios and sensitivities	Sets the price and the walk-away
05	**Drafting**	Writes first drafts to the template, with every claim linked to evidence	Edits the story and the commitments
06	**Cross-checks**	Compares numbers and dates across bid, model, board paper and other submissions	Resolves every flagged conflict
07	**Review and sign-off**	Assembles the review pack and the decision log	Signs off: CEO or delegated authority
08	**Lessons back in**	Records the outcome, clearing data and feedback, and updates the library	Agrees changes for the next bid

Agents prepare; named people decide at every step. Source: Ignis.

Under the workflow sits a deliberately boring stack: one evidence library per project, one pricing model per project linked to that library, a template set for each bid type, and an access and audit log. Ignis agents provide the agent layer for this work. The Ignis system is in pilot, and we make no performance claims for it here. The design is meant to be useful on any toolset.

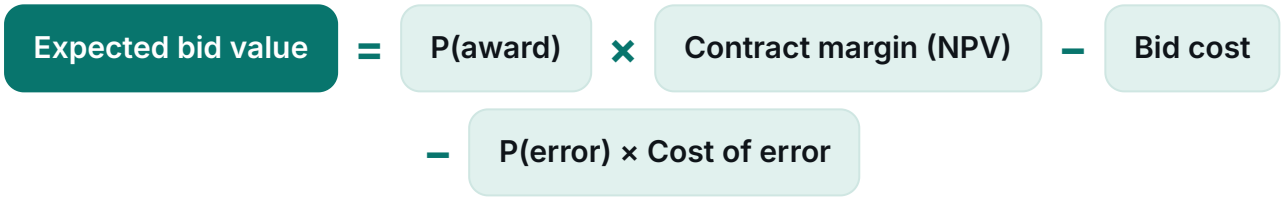
What stays human
Price, walk-away, partner terms, risk allocation, anything that commits capital, and the final sign-off. If an agent output would change any of these, it goes to a named person first.

5 · RISK AND VALUE

How should an IPP value a bid before writing it?

SHORT ANSWER
Treat each bid as an option. Its value is the chance of winning multiplied by the margin if you win, less the bid cost and the expected cost of errors. In a pay-as-clear CfD round, bidding lower changes your chance of winning, not the price you receive, so the floor price matters more than the bid price.

FIGURE 10
Expected value of a bid



A simple expected-value frame for bid or no-bid decisions. Source: Ignis.

Each term has an owner. **P(award)** depends on how competitive the price is and how strong the evidence is. **Contract margin** depends on the strike or contract price, yield, capex and tenor. **Bid cost** is mostly senior time. **P(error) × cost of error** is the term most teams leave out. It covers a delivery year the grid date cannot meet, a capex input that is six months out of date, or a PPA offer that contradicts the CfD bid.

Two consequences follow. First, in a CfD round all successful projects in a pot receive the clearing price, [1] so the highest-value pricing work is setting an honest floor from current capex, yield and grid evidence, not shaving the bid. Second, the cheapest way to raise expected value is usually to cut the error term with cross-checks, rather than to add more drafting hours.

6 · WORKED EXAMPLE

What is a solar and battery bid worth getting right?

SHORT ANSWER
In our illustrative 60 MW solar case, £1/MWh on the strike price is worth about £58,000 a year, or about £0.6m in present value over a 20-year CfD. A one-year slip in the grid date defers about £3.8m of revenue. The pricing floor and the grid date matter far more than drafting polish.

The example is a hypothetical co-located project: 60 MW of solar and a 30 MW / 60 MWh battery. The team is considering an AR8 CfD for the solar plus a route-to-market PPA, a toll or floor for the battery, and a Capacity Market entry. Public numbers anchor the case. Everything else is an assumption, labelled in Table 3.

TABLE 3 ILLUSTRATIVE
Worked example inputs

INPUT	VALUE	BASIS
Solar capacity	60 MW	Illustrative
Load factor	11% (range 10–12%)	Illustrative assumption
Annual generation	57,816 MWh	60 × 8,760 × 11%
CfD reference price	£65.23/MWh (2024 prices)	AR7a clearing [1]
CfD term	20 years, CPI-indexed	Scheme Update 2025 [6]
Discount rate	7% real	Illustrative assumption
Battery	30 MW / 60 MWh	Illustrative
Battery floor reference	About £44k/MW/year	Modo, derived from the Gresham floors (£35m ÷ 789 MW) [17]
Capacity Market price	£27.10/kW/year	T-4 2029/30 [12]
Battery de-rating factor	21%	Illustrative assumption

Source: Public anchors as cited; all other values are illustrative.

TABLE 4 ILLUSTRATIVE

Annual solar CfD revenue by clearing price and load factor (£m, 2024 prices)

LOAD FACTOR	£60/MWH	£65.23/MWH (AR7A)	£70/MWH	£75/MWH (ASP)
10%	3.15	3.43	3.68	3.94
11%	3.47	**3.77**	4.05	4.34
12%	3.78	4.11	4.42	4.73

A one-point error in yield moves revenue by about as much as a £5–6/MWh move in price. Yield evidence deserves the same scrutiny as the bid price. Source: Ignis illustrative calculation: generation × price. Excludes indexation, curtailment and negative-price rules.

TABLE 5 ILLUSTRATIVE

What each decision is worth in this example

DECISION	ILLUSTRATIVE VALUE	HOW IT IS DERIVED
£1/MWh on the floor price	≈ £58k a year; ≈ £0.61m present value over 20 years	57,816 MWh × £1; annuity at 7% (10.59)
Grid date slips a year	≈ £3.8m of revenue deferred	57,816 MWh × £65.23
Battery floor rather than fully merchant	≈ £1.32m a year of downside protection	30 MW × £44k/MW [17]
Capacity Market entry	≈ £0.17m a year	30 MW × 21% × £27.10/kW [12]

The decisions that are worth most are the floor price, the grid date and the battery contract. These need senior time. Drafting does not. Source: Ignis illustrative calculation from Table 3.

Read across the tables and the order of priorities becomes clear. An agent-supported desk does not make the price decision. It ensures that the price decision is taken early, on current evidence, and that the CfD bid, the PPA offer, the

battery term sheet and the Gate 2 acceptance all describe the same project with the same dates.

7 · IMPLICATIONS

What should IPP CEOs do now?

SHORT ANSWER

Decide which competitions you will enter for each project, and set the floor price before any drafting starts. Put each project's evidence in one place. Make cross-checks a step that bids cannot skip. Hand drafting and checking to agents under named owners, and measure senior hours on judgement rather than on production.

1. **Set a portfolio bid calendar.** List every CfD, PPA, toll, Capacity Market and Gate 2 event for the next 12 months against the people available. Decline early where load exceeds capacity.
2. **Fix the floor before the bid.** Agree each project's walk-away on current capex, yield and grid evidence at the bid or no-bid gate, not in the final week.
3. **One project, one evidence library.** Every bid draws on the same approved facts. Stale items are flagged automatically.
4. **Make cross-checks mandatory.** No submission leaves until dates, capacity and prices match the model and every other live submission.
5. **Measure the right hours.** Track senior time on judgement, relationships and negotiation against time on coordination and production. Aim to double the first while cutting the total. Move production work to agents with named reviewers.

For investors, the outcome is a bid record they can audit: why each bid was entered, at what floor, on which evidence and with whose sign-off. That record supports the board pack and the lender pack at financial close.

8 · METHOD AND SOURCES

How was this analysis done?

SHORT ANSWER

From public UK sources only: DESNZ round results and notices, Ofgem, NESO, and published market and company data. Where no public data exists, such as bid hours, we use clearly labelled illustrative modelling with every assumption stated.

Data. Public sources only, listed below and accessed in October 2026. AR7a project sizes were parsed from the DESNZ results table (157 solar rows, which reconcile to the published 4,905.01 MW). Capacity Market prices are from Ofgem's Table 1.

Illustrative modelling. Figure 7 and Table 2, Table 3, Table 4 and Table 5 are illustrative. Bid hours (including the 20/80 conventional split and the 40/30 agent-supported split in Figure 7), event counts, load factor, discount rate and battery de-rating are assumptions based on Ignis practitioner experience, not measurements. The calculations are simple and shown so they can be reproduced.

Limitations. No public dataset covers bid hours or bid costs. The PPA buyer range is approximated from Pexapark's statement that buyers' best bids sit £5–10 below sellers' offers. CfD prices are in 2024 prices and CPI-indexed, while PPA

quotes are not, so the two are not directly comparable. Revenue figures exclude indexation, curtailment, negative-price rules and balancing costs.

Not covered. Offshore wind, Ireland, France and Iberia. France's AO10 tender has its own Ignis news note.

APPENDIX A

Is your bid desk ready for portfolio scale?

SHORT ANSWER
Score eight statements. Seven or more means the desk can take on more rounds. Three or fewer means the bid or no-bid gate is the first fix.

- ☐ We hold a 12-month calendar of every bid event across the portfolio.
- ☐ Each bid has a written bid or no-bid decision with a floor price.
- ☐ Each project has one evidence library, with owners and dates.
- ☐ Pricing models are linked to the latest capex, yield and grid inputs.
- ☐ Dates and capacity are cross-checked across all live submissions.
- ☐ Every price and risk decision has a named owner and a sign-off record.
- ☐ Drafting and checking do not depend on one or two people.
- ☐ Outcomes and clearing data feed back into the next bid.

7–8
Ready to scale: bid more rounds

4–6
Fix the gaps before AR8 and the next Gate 2 wave

0–3
Bid fewer, better: start with the bid or no-bid gate

APPENDIX B

Questions to ask your team on Monday

1. Which bid events fall in the next 90 days, and who owns each one?
2. What is our floor price for each, and when was it last tested?
3. Where does the same project appear with different dates or numbers?
4. How many senior hours went on production rather than judgement, relationships and negotiation last month?
5. What did we learn from the last round, and where is it written down?

APPENDIX C · FIRST 30 DAYS WITH IGNIS

WEEK 1
Gap review
One recent bid traced end to end

WEEK 2
Map
12-month bid calendar and load

WEEK 3
Design
Evidence library, gates and owners

WEEK 4
Live call
One bid or no-bid run through the workflow

The Ignis system is in pilot. Founding clients shape the product and their terms.

Talk to Ignis about your next bid → ignisleadership.com/contact

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